USING THE TOOLS OF THE TRADE

Most DAWs (digital audio workstations) or audio editing software usually come with a set of tools that can help mitigate some of the commonly-occurring problems in the podcast's audio quality. Some of these tools include high-pass filter, EQ, compressor, and de-esser. A high-pass filter only allows sound above a predetermined frequency to pass through while filtering everything else out. Since most human voices don't generate any fundamental frequencies below approximately 85 Hz, it would be a good idea to set the high-pass filter in your DAW to around 80-100 Hz. This helps remove distracting rumble and plosives that may bother your listeners.

An EQ is an important tool that you will find in most audio editing software. A bit of equalisation can help compensate for resonances in your recording area, or certain unsightly frequencies. However, be wary of excessively using the EQ and avoid boosts or cuts of frequencies more than about 6dB.

Compressions take loud sounds and turn them down to even out the difference in dynamics of sound in your recording. The difference between softer and louder parts of your podcast recording won't be quite so jarring if you use healthy levels of compression. However, avoid using this to the extremes as well.

De-essing is essentially a blend between compression and equalisation. It compresses your voice but only in the frequency range where harsh sibilant sounds are present (4-7 kHz). This is useful for people that have a more sibilant sound when speaking into the microphone. Compression can make your voice more warm and pleasant to listen to. Sibilant sounds can be fatiguing, especially over long periods of time. Again, as all things mentioned here, it is unwise to overuse this tool or you could lose the intelligibility of your voice.

Image credit: Milo Burke

De-essing reduces the amount of sibilance in your voice

CHOOSING AN AUDIO EDITING SOFTWARE

The market is flooded with options for good audio editing software that work well for editing podcasts. Choosing the right audio editing software for your podcast is crucial since you will likely spend a significant amount of time making sure everything sounds as perfect as it can be and you need a software that provides you with the right set of tools. Adding intros, outros, music, secondary voice recordings (from guests or co-hosts), and more is all possible via a good audio editing software. Let's look at a few options you could choose from.

MISCELLANEOUS TIPS FOR RECORDING PODCASTS

- Clean audio clips by eliminating long, unwanted dead air
- Remove um, ah, mm sounds and repetitions that do not contribute to the content
- Place music tracks strategically so that they do not disturb the voice of the podcaster
- If your audio editing software supports it, convert your 16 bit audio to 24 bit before going through process such as compression, de-essing, and EQ to retain quality
- If your podcast is mostly voices, the bitrate of your MP3 can be as low as 96kbps (62kbps for mono), if it has music keep the bitrate at least 192kbps (128kbps for mono)
- You can also choose constant bitrate or variable bitrate. A variable bitrate makes the more complex parts sound better without taking up extra space for simpler parts

Adobe Audition

Adobe Audition is a part of the Creative Cloud Suite, so if you already have a subscription to the full suite, you will get access to this software as well. It is also available for $20 per month separately. The software has advanced tools for podcast editing that allow users to reduce external sounds, perform advanced compression, EQ, and much more. There's also a nifty batch processing feature where you can apply several effects onto one file, save it and then apply the same effects to a batch of files, which saves tons of time. The software is available for both Windows and macOS.

Pro Tools

Pro Tools is one of the most feature-laden audio editing software out there. It has